Chatbot Options in Zoho

A plain-language guide to every way you can build a chatbot with Zoho, and which one fits a course-advisor bot for the DataSphere website

Prepared by: Venkatesh Biradar
Internship: DataSphere
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1. Summary in one page

Zoho is an Indian software company (headquartered in Chennai) that sells 55+ business apps: CRM, email, accounting, helpdesk, website chat and more. There is no single "Zoho chatbot". Instead, chatbots can be built in **several different Zoho products**, each meant for a different job.

Option	What it is in one line	Good for
SalesIQ + Zobot	The chat bubble on a website, with a bot inside it	Talking to website visitors, capturing leads
Answer Bot	A bot that answers by searching your help articles	Simple FAQs (timings, fees, policies)
Zoho Desk + Zia	AI inside the customer-support ticket system	Support teams handling complaints and tickets
Zoho Cliq bots	Bots inside Zoho's Slack-like team chat	Employees, not customers
Own AI bot + Zoho CRM	Your own AI brain; Zoho only stores the leads	Smart conversations, e.g. course advice

> **Bottom line for DataSphere:** the website needs a bot that *understands* a student's background and goals and *recommends* the right courses. Zoho's ready-made bots are good at fixed menus and FAQs, but weak at real advising. The best fit is **our own AI chatbot (RAG + a large language model) that sends interested visitors to Zoho CRM as leads**. Section 10 explains why, and Section 11 explains how to build it.

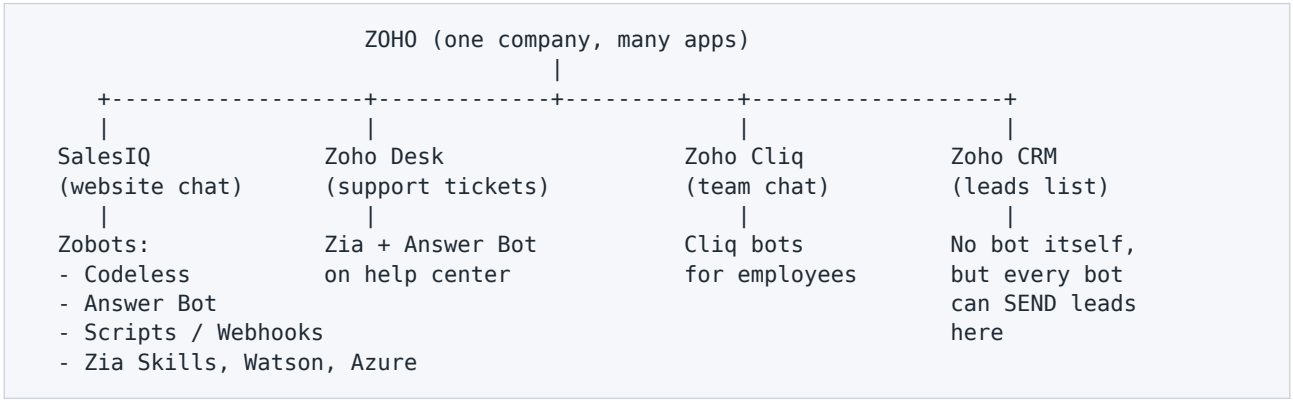
2. First, some simple words (glossary)

These words come up again and again. Here they are in everyday language.

Word	Simple meaning
Chatbot	A computer program that chats with people in a text box, like a receptionist who never sleeps.
Rule-based bot	Follows a fixed script: "If the person clicks A, say X". It cannot handle anything outside the script.
AI / NLP bot	Understands normal sentences (NLP = Natural Language Processing). You can type in your own words.
LLM	Large Language Model, e.g. Claude or ChatGPT. A very capable AI that can read, reason and write like a person.
Knowledge base (KB)	A collection of help articles / FAQs a company writes, like a FAQ binder.
RAG	Retrieval-Augmented Generation. Before answering, the bot first **looks up** the right information (retrieval), then the AI **writes** an answer using only that information (generation). It is like an open-book exam: the AI answers from your books, not from memory, so it does not make things up.
Lead	A potential customer who has shown interest and shared contact details (name, phone, email).
CRM	Customer Relationship Management. A digital register of all leads and customers, so the sales team can follow up. Zoho CRM is one.
Webhook	A way for one app to automatically send a message to another app's web address. Like a doorbell: when something happens, it rings your server.
API	A door through which one program can talk to another, e.g. our code adding a lead into Zoho CRM.
Deluge	Zoho's own simple programming language, used to add custom logic inside Zoho apps.
Zia	Zoho's AI assistant brand name, like Siri for Zoho apps.
Operator / agent	A real human staff member who replies in the chat.

3. Zoho's products where chatbots live

Think of Zoho as a big office building with different departments. Chatbots can work in four of those departments:



Why so many? Each product solves a different business problem. Website visitors, customers with complaints, and employees talking to each other are different audiences, so each product has its own kind of bot. They are not competitors; they are different tools in the same toolbox.

4. Option 1: Zoho SalesIQ and Zobots

What is SalesIQ? SalesIQ is Zoho's **website chat platform**. It is the little chat bubble in the corner of a website that says "Hi! How can we help?". If the website is a shop, SalesIQ is the shop's front desk.

What SalesIQ gives you:

- **Chat widget**: the bubble, added to any website by pasting one script tag.
- **Live chat**: real staff can reply from the Zoho dashboard or mobile app.
- **Visitor tracking**: which pages a visitor opened, how long they stayed, where they came from.
- **Chat history**: every conversation is saved.
- **CRM sync**: visitor details can flow into Zoho CRM as leads.
- **Zobots**: bots that reply automatically when no human is free.

What is a Zobot? "Zobot" is simply Zoho's name for **any bot running inside SalesIQ**. The front desk is SalesIQ; the Zobot is the receptionist sitting at it. When you create a Zobot, Zoho asks you to choose a **platform**, meaning *how the receptionist's brain is built*:

Zobot platform	How it works (simple words)	Coding?	Best for
Codeless Bot Builder	Drag-and-drop flowchart: ask name, show buttons, branch on answers.	No	Menus, simple lead forms, appointment booking
Answer Bot	Searches your help articles and replies with the best match (see Section 5).	No	FAQs
SalesIQ Scripts (Deluge)	You write small Zoho scripts that decide each reply.	Yes (Deluge)	Custom logic staying inside Zoho
Webhooks	SalesIQ forwards every message to **your own server**; your code replies.	Yes (any language)	Plugging in your own AI / LLM
Zia Skills	Teach Zoho's assistant Zia specific skills/intents.	Low	Zoho-native AI actions
Watson / Azure Bot	Connect a bot already built on IBM Watson or Microsoft Azure.	Yes	Companies already using those

Strengths: quick to start, live human handoff, built-in visitor tracking, direct link to Zoho CRM.

Weaknesses: codeless bots are rigid (they break when people type something unexpected); the bot features are usually only in paid plans; deep AI behaviour needs Scripts or Webhooks, which means coding anyway.

> **Example:** A codeless Zobot can do "Welcome! Choose: [Courses] [Fees] [Talk to counselor]". But if a student types "I'm in 3rd year ECE, I know a bit of Python, what should I learn for a data job?", a codeless bot cannot really answer.

5. Option 2: Answer Bot

What is it? Answer Bot is Zoho's ready-made **"answer from documents"** bot. The company writes help articles / FAQs in Zoho's knowledge base. When a visitor asks a question, Answer Bot finds the most relevant article and replies with it. Newer versions use Zia's generative AI to rewrite the answer in a natural way, which is a simple form of RAG.

Think of it as a receptionist with a FAQ binder: very fast at looking things up, but it only knows what is written in the binder.

Where it appears: as a Zobot type in SalesIQ (website chat), and inside Zoho Desk's help center (Section 6).

Answer Bot can do	Answer Bot struggles with
"What are your office timings?"	Asking the student follow-up questions about their background
"Is there a placement guarantee?"	Comparing 3 courses and building a learning path
"How do I get a refund?"	Personal recommendations ("what should *I* take?")
Pointing to the right article link	Anything not already written in an article

Why it exists separately from SalesIQ: SalesIQ is the whole chat platform; Answer Bot is *one kind of brain* you can put inside it (and inside Zoho Desk). It exists because many businesses just want FAQ answers with zero coding.

6. Option 3: Zoho Desk + Zia

What is Zoho Desk? Zoho Desk is a **customer-support helpdesk**. When a customer emails a complaint or raises an issue, it becomes a "ticket" that support staff track until it is solved.

Where the bot comes in: Zia (Zoho's AI) is built into Desk. It can:

- Answer customers on the help center using Answer Bot, which drafts replies from knowledge-base articles (RAG-style).
- Optionally fall back to OpenAI's ChatGPT for general questions, if the admin connects it.
- Suggest replies to support staff, summarise long tickets, and detect the customer's mood (angry / happy).
- Point out **gaps**: questions customers keep asking that have no article yet.

Good for: after-sales support, e.g. "I paid but can't access my course", "certificate not received".

Not meant for: selling and advising new website visitors. That is SalesIQ's job.

> **Point to note:** the bot is only as good as the articles written. If the knowledge base is thin, answers will be thin. Connecting ChatGPT also sends company data to a third party and adds usage costs.

7. Option 4: Zoho Cliq bots

What is Zoho Cliq? Zoho's team chat app, similar to Slack or Microsoft Teams, used by **employees inside the company**.

Cliq bots can answer staff questions ("what is the leave policy?"), send alerts ("new lead from website!"), or run small tasks. They are built with Deluge scripts or webhooks.

For the course website, Cliq is not the right tool, since students never see Cliq. It could still be useful as an add-on: for example, posting a message in the sales team's Cliq channel whenever the website bot captures a hot lead.

8. Option 5: Your own AI chatbot + Zoho CRM

What is it? Instead of using Zoho's bot brain, we build our **own AI brain** (an LLM such as Claude, plus RAG over our course data) and put a chat widget on the website. Zoho is used only for what it is great at: **storing and managing leads in Zoho CRM**.

In simple words: **our bot does the talking and advising; Zoho CRM keeps the register of interested students** so the sales team can call them.

Advantages	Disadvantages
Real conversations: asks about background, goals, time and budget	Needs some coding (Python) and hosting
Smart recommendations and learning paths from our own course data	We must maintain it (update course data, fix issues)
Full control over tone, rules and design	No built-in live-human dashboard (can be added later)
Does not require a paid SalesIQ bot plan	LLM usage has a small per-chat cost
Will not invent courses: RAG keeps answers grounded in our data	

A hybrid is also possible: keep the SalesIQ chat bubble (to get live human handoff and visitor tracking) and connect our AI brain to it using the **Webhooks** Zobot platform. This gives the best of both, at the cost of a paid SalesIQ plan and a bit more integration work.

9. Side-by-side comparison

	Codeless Zobot	Answer Bot	Desk + Zia	Own AI + CRM
Main audience	Website visitors	Website / help center visitors	Existing customers	Website visitors
Understands free text	Poorly	Yes (FAQ-level)	Yes (FAQ-level)	Yes, very well
Asks follow-up questions	Only fixed ones	No	No	Yes, naturally
Personal course suggestions	No	No	No	**Yes**
Lead capture to CRM	Yes	Limited	Not its job	Yes (via API)
Human handoff	Yes	Yes	Yes (tickets)	Add later / hybrid
Coding needed	None	None	None	Python
Setup time	Hours	Hours (+ writing articles)	Days	2-3 days demo, 1-2 weeks polished
Control / customisation	Low	Low	Medium	Full

10. Recommendation for the DataSphere course bot

The goal is a website assistant that can **answer anything about our courses, suggest the right courses** to each visitor, and **turn interested visitors into leads**.

- Codeless Zobot: too rigid for advising.
- Answer Bot / Desk + Zia: good for FAQs, but they cannot interview a student and build recommendations.
- Cliq: internal only; wrong audience.

> **Recommended:** Option 5, **our own RAG chatbot using an LLM, connected to Zoho CRM for leads**. If the team later wants live counselors to jump into chats, upgrade to the hybrid (SalesIQ bubble + Webhook to our AI) without rebuilding the brain.

11. How the recommended chatbot works and how to build it

How one message travels

```
  Visitor on DataSphere website
          |  types: "I want to get into data science"
          v
  [ Chat bubble on website ]
          |  (1) message sent to our server
          v
  +-------------------------------------------------+
  |  OUR BACKEND  (Python + FastAPI)                |
  |  (2) load this visitor's earlier messages       |
  |  (3) RETRIEVE matching courses  <- courses data |
  |  (4) send question + courses to the LLM (Claude) |
  |  (5) LLM writes a reply, or decides to          |
  |      save a lead  ---------------------------> ZOHO CRM (Leads)
  +-------------------------------------------------+
          |  (6) reply sent back
          v
  Visitor sees: "Great goal! Are you a student or working,
                 and do you know any Python?"
```

Example conversation

Visitor: I want to get into data science

Bot: Great goal! Are you a student or working? Any coding experience?

Visitor: 3rd year B.Tech, a little Python

Bot: Then I'd suggest (1) *Python for Data Analysis*, 6 weeks, then (2) *Machine Learning Foundations*, 8 weeks. Want a counselor to call you with fee and batch details?

Visitor: Yes. Rahul, 98xxxxxx10

Bot: Done! Our team will call you soon. → *Lead created automatically in Zoho CRM*

Build steps

Step	What we do	In simple words
1. Course data	Collect every course into one file: name, level, duration, fee, mode, prerequisites, topics, who it suits, next course.	Write the bot's textbook. The bot is only as good as this data.
2. Backend brain	Python FastAPI server with a /chat endpoint that does retrieval + calls the LLM and remembers each visitor's conversation.	Build the brain.
3. Rules (prompt)	Instructions: ask 1-2 questions first, recommend max 3 courses, only from our data, never invent fees or dates, offer a counselor.	Train the receptionist's manners.
4. Lead tool	A save_lead function that calls the Zoho CRM API (OAuth login) to create a Lead with name, phone, email, interested courses, chat summary.	Connect the brain to the leads register.

Step	What we do	In simple words
5. Chat widget	A small chat bubble added to the website with one script tag.	Put the front desk on the website.
6. Test	Try tricky questions: "cheapest course?", "I know nothing", "do you teach blockchain?" (should say no, not invent).	Mock interview before the job.
7. Deploy	Host the backend (Render / Railway / company server). Keep API keys secret in environment variables.	Open for business.

Do we need a vector database? Only for lots of long documents (full syllabi, PDFs, blogs). If DataSphere has under ~100 courses, the whole catalog fits directly in the AI's instructions. That is simpler, cheaper and often more accurate. A vector database (e.g. Chroma, pgvector) can be added later.

12. Costs, risks and things to check

Costs (approximate; confirm before deciding)

- **LLM usage:** pay-per-use. With a fast, low-cost model, a typical chat costs only a few rupees or less.
- **Hosting:** free to low cost on platforms like Render/Railway for a starter version.
- **Zoho CRM:** the company likely already has it; API access is included in paid CRM editions.
- **SalesIQ (only for the hybrid):** has a free tier with limits, but bot features appear to need a paid plan. Third-party sites list different INR prices, so check zoho.com/salesiq/pricing directly.

Risks and how we handle them

Risk	How we reduce it
AI invents a course or wrong fee	RAG + strict rule: answer only from course data; say "I'll connect you to a counselor" when unsure.
Outdated course data	One single course file that the team updates; the bot reads it automatically.
Privacy of student details	Collect only name/phone/email with consent; send them straight to Zoho CRM; keep API keys secret.
Misuse / off-topic chats	Prompt keeps the bot on DataSphere topics; limit message length and rate.
Bot can't help	Always offer a human counselor (phone/WhatsApp, or SalesIQ in the hybrid).

Things to confirm with the DataSphere team

- Full, up-to-date course list with fees and batch dates.
- Which Zoho apps and plans the company already pays for (CRM edition? SalesIQ?).
- Which lead fields the sales team wants (e.g. course interest, city, college, year).
- Whether live human chat is needed in version 1 or can come later.

13. Sources

Zoho features change often; verify on Zoho's official pages before final decisions.

Zoho SalesIQ: Create a Zobot (platform list): https://www.zoho.com/salesiq/help/developer-guides/create-bot.html

Zoho SalesIQ: SalesIQ Script introduction: https://www.zoho.com/salesiq/help/developer-guides/bot-salesiq-script.html

Zoho SalesIQ glossary: Zobot: https://www.zoho.com/salesiq/glossary/zobot.html

Zoho Desk AI (Zia): https://www.zoho.com/desk/ai.html

Zoho community: Zia GenAI for Zoho Desk / Answer Bot RAG: https://help.zoho.com/portal/en/community/zoho-desk

Zoho SalesIQ plan comparison: https://www.zoho.com/salesiq/pricing-comparison.html

eesel.ai: A practical guide to Zoho Desk Generative AI (2025): https://www.eesel.ai/blog/zoho-desk-generative-ai